Budget Stabilization Progress Updates



Progress Update

Last year, MUSD engaged with School Leaders to assess district finances and provide recommendations for long-term budget stabilization.

School Leaders concluded that the district is financially stable. The District is working through the process of financial strategy to accomplish long term stability.

Today’s Update

- Review progress on recommendations
- Highlight departmental strategies and actions
- Identify ongoing efforts to support long-term fiscal sustainability



Human Resources

Department Progress

Recommendations

1. Establish HR-Fiscal Position Control and Reconciliation
2. Implement standardized staffing dashboard
3. Adopt a formal vacancy replacement protocol
4. Standardize and fully implement position control Workflows/Routing Protocols and District Approval Systems.
5. Initiate Targeted Staffing Reductions

What is position control?

Position control is the district's system for ensuring that every employee is connected to an authorized and funded position.

- Identifies and Tracks Approved district positions
- Shows whether each position is filled or vacant (Real Time)
- Connects the position to its school or department and funding source through HR/ Fiscal monthly reconciliation.
- Keeps staffing decisions aligned with the district budget



Informed K12

Defines workflows and requires Department collaboration

Improves practices at all levels of the organization

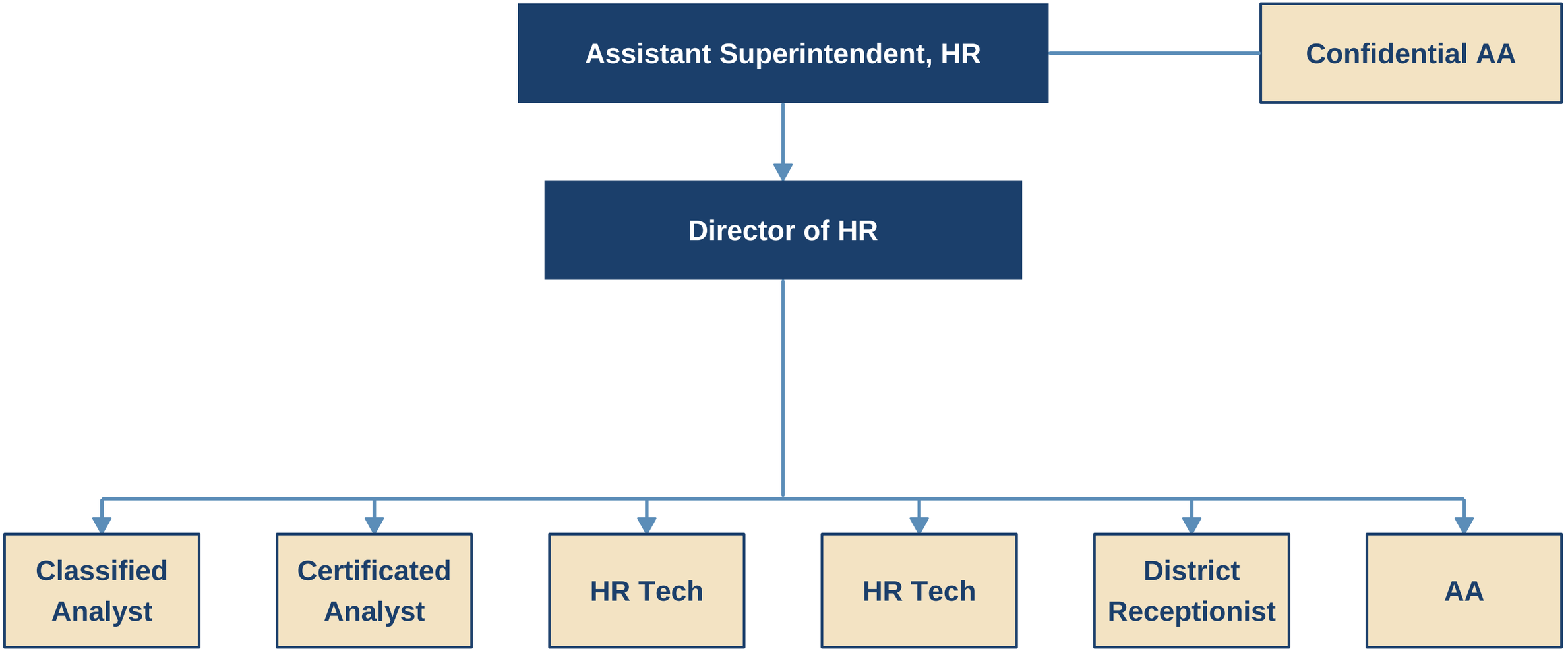
Automates Forms, Signatures, and Approval Processes/ Workflows

Efficient Reconciliation Monthly

Provides real-time tracking and accountability

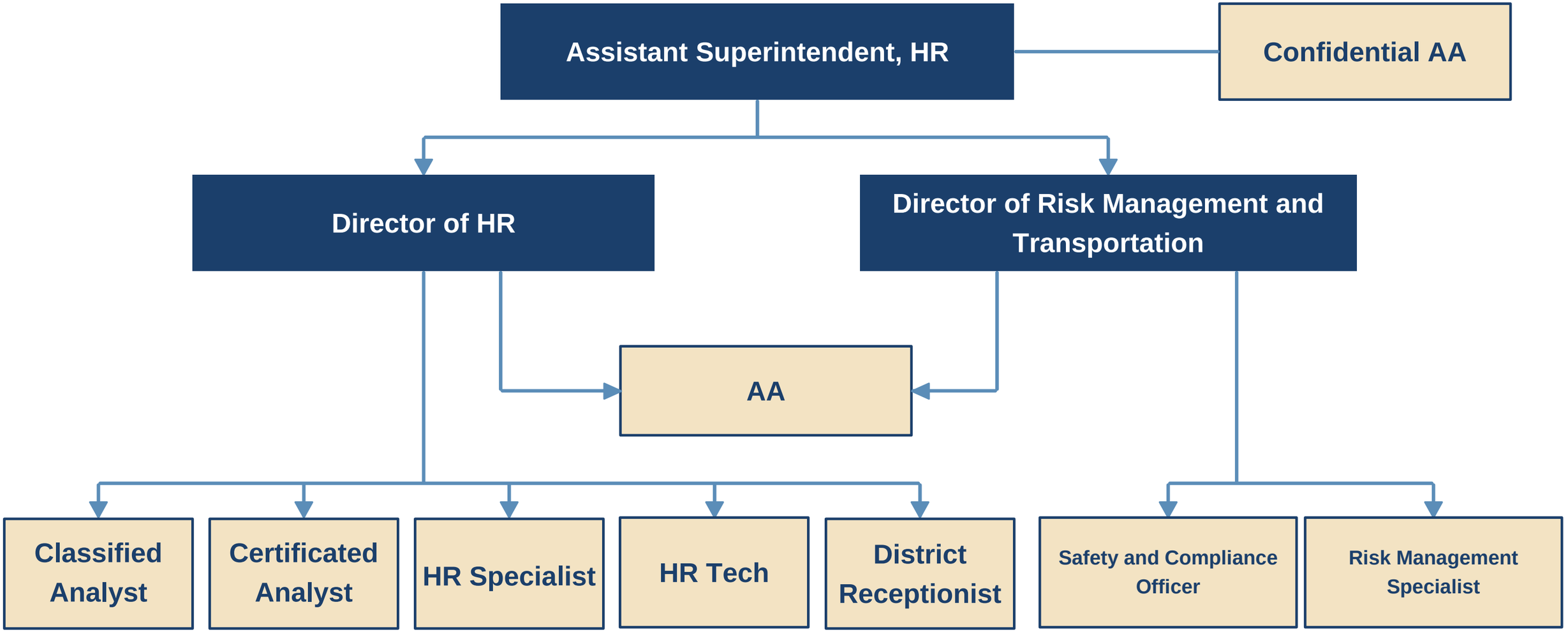
Will speed up Hiring Practices

Previous HR Structure



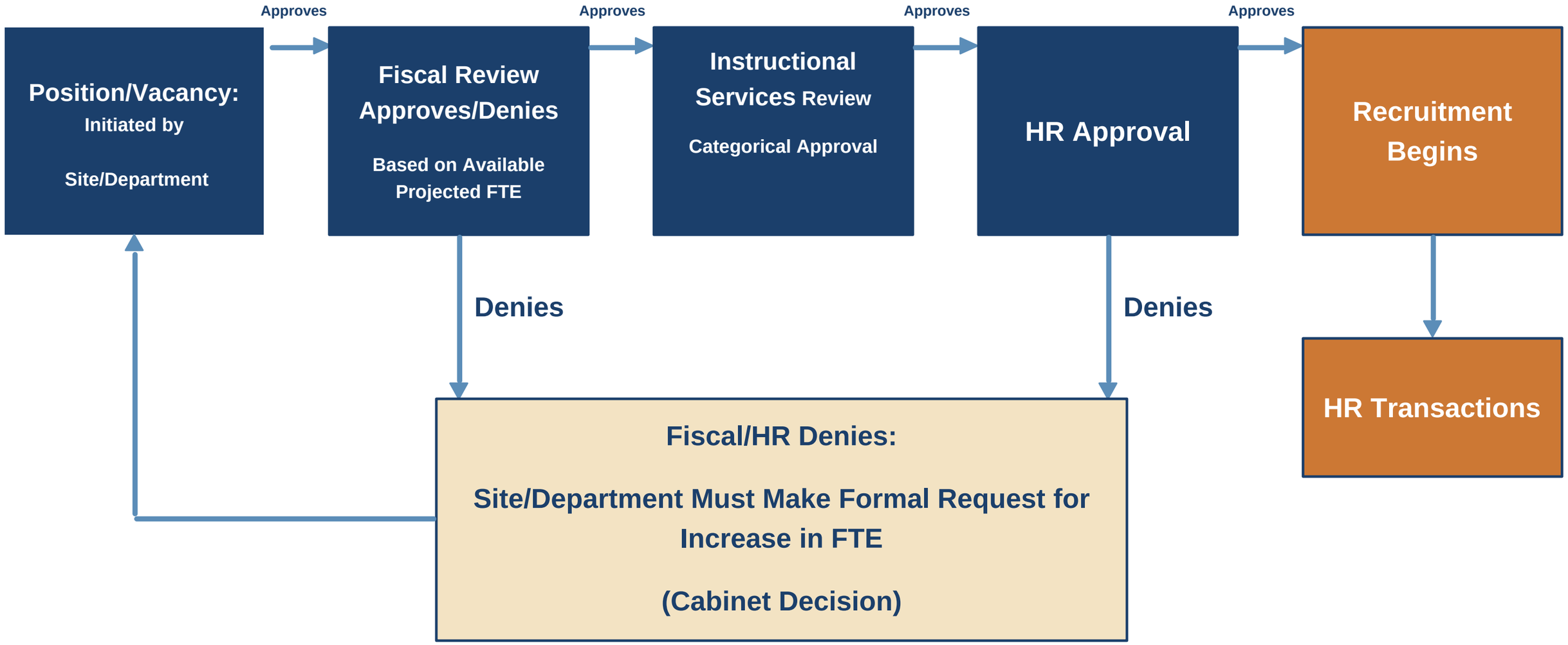
Human Resources Division Reorganization

This reorganization eliminated two vacant classified positions (HR Technician and Account Specialist Benefits).

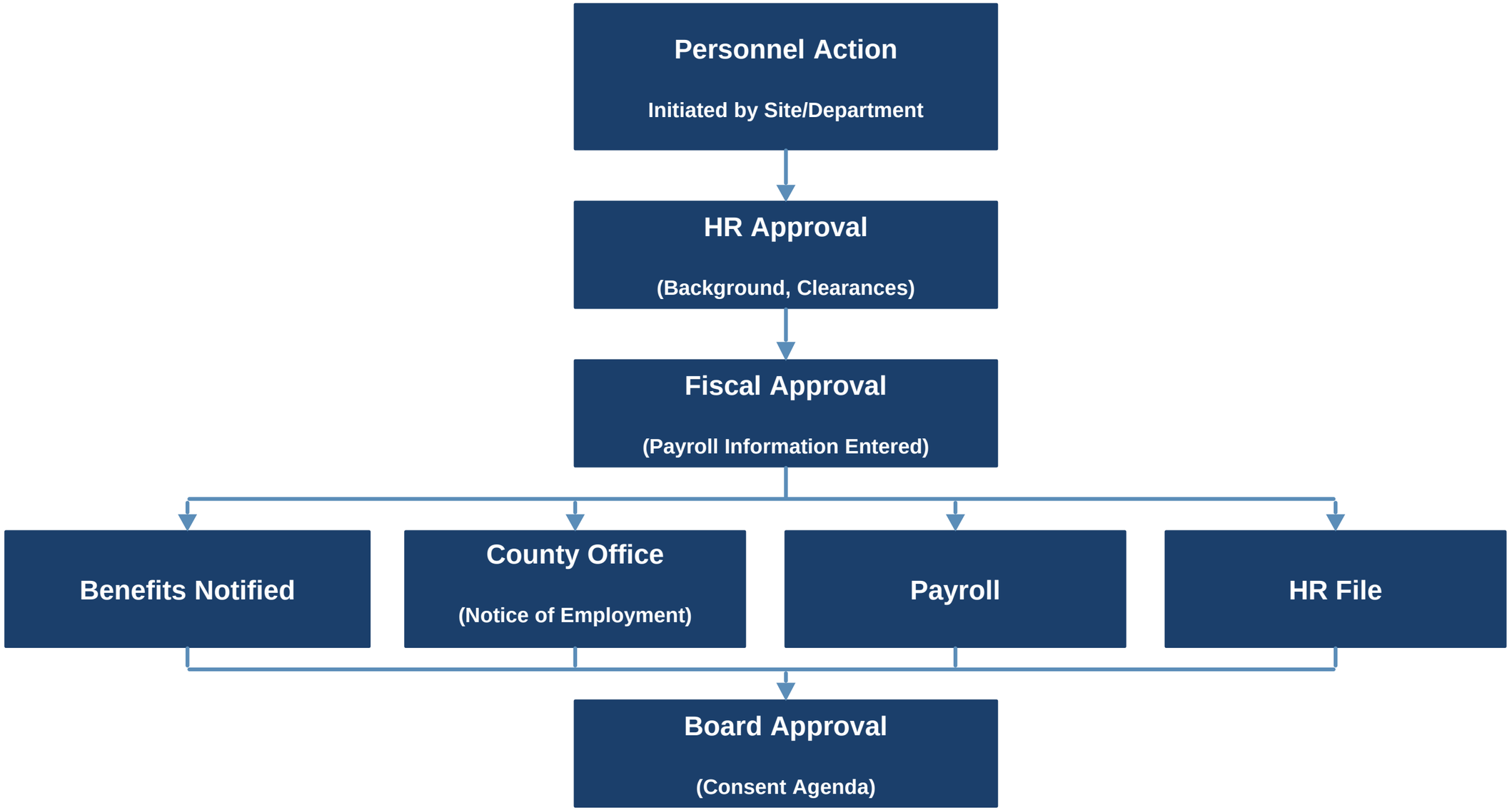


Human Resources Transaction Workflow

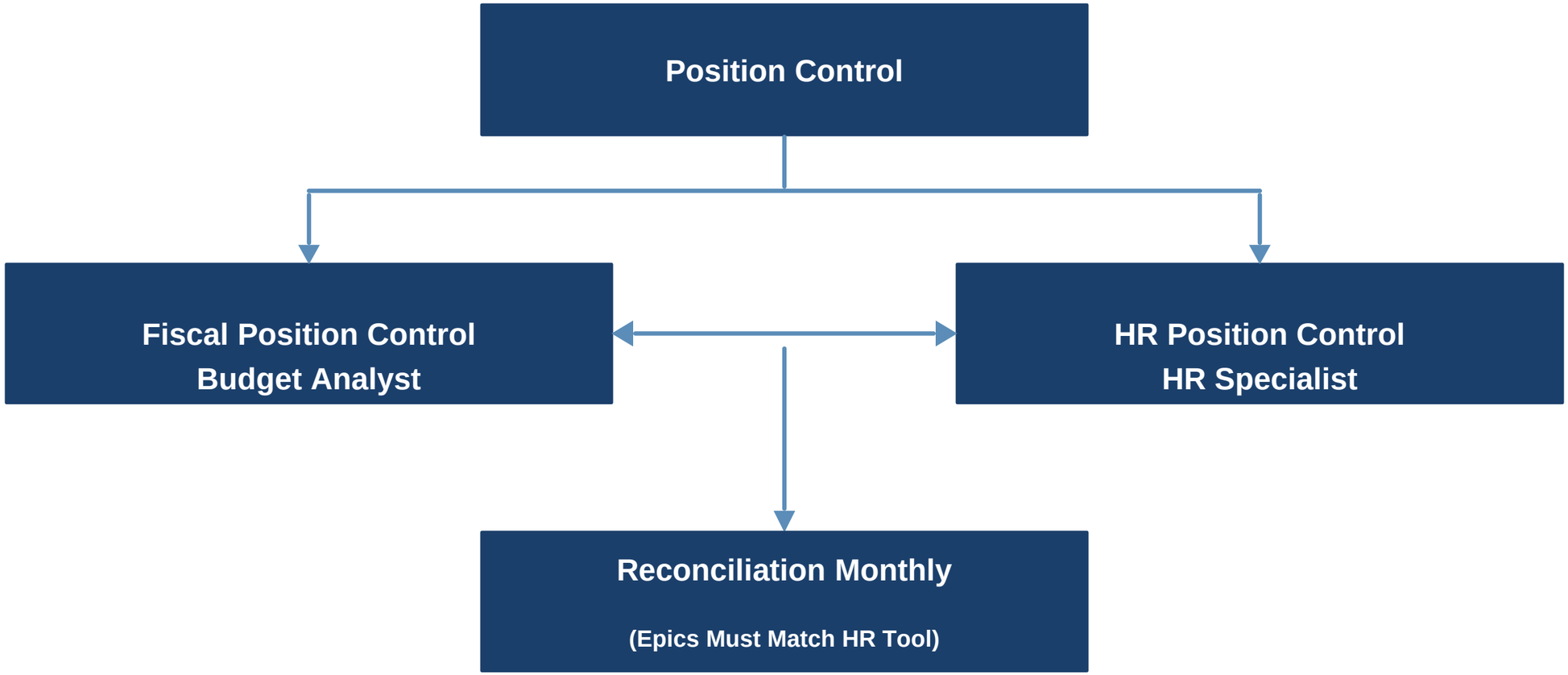
Position Control Through HR Transactions



Human Resources Transaction Approval



Position Control





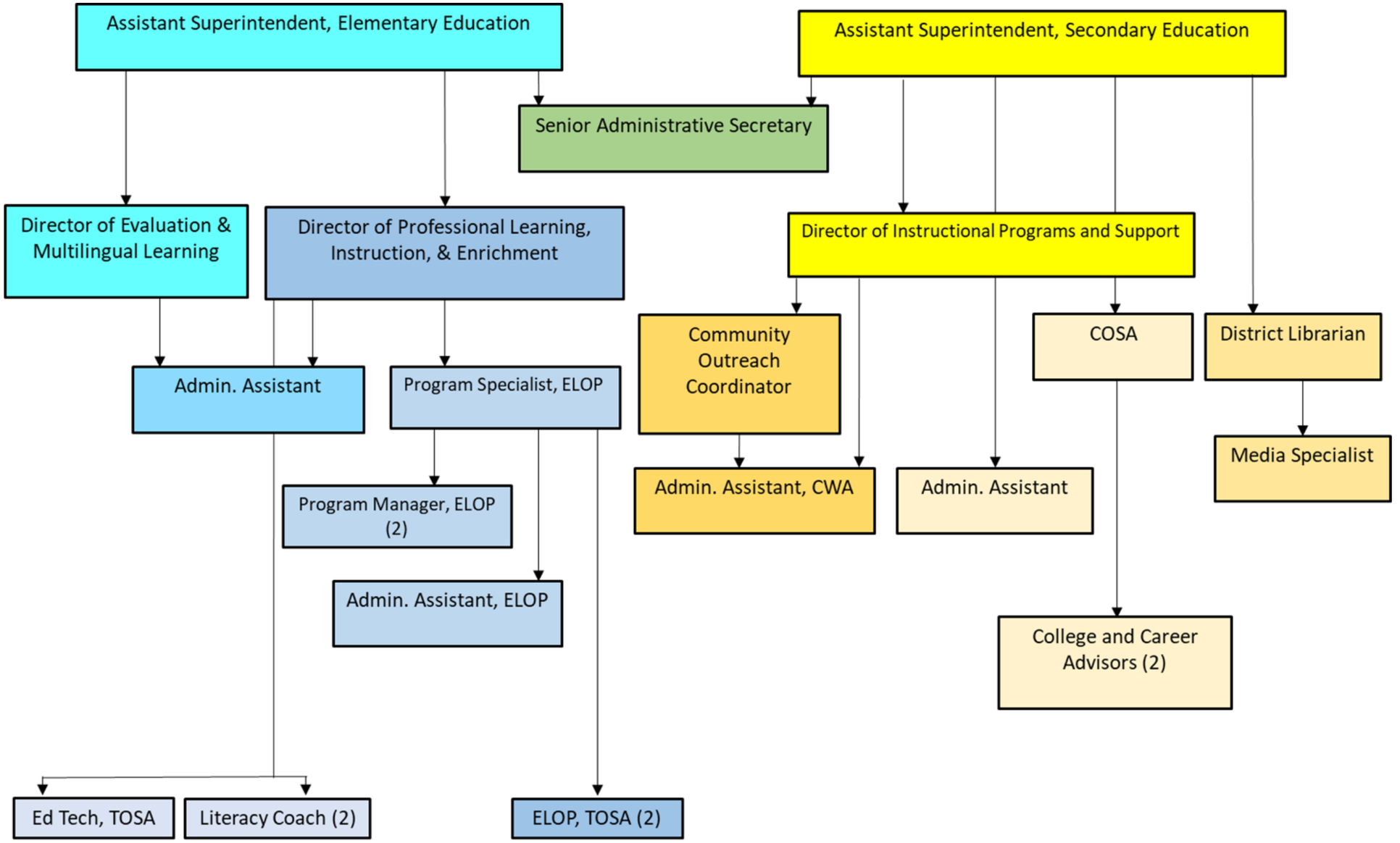
Instructional Services

Department Progress

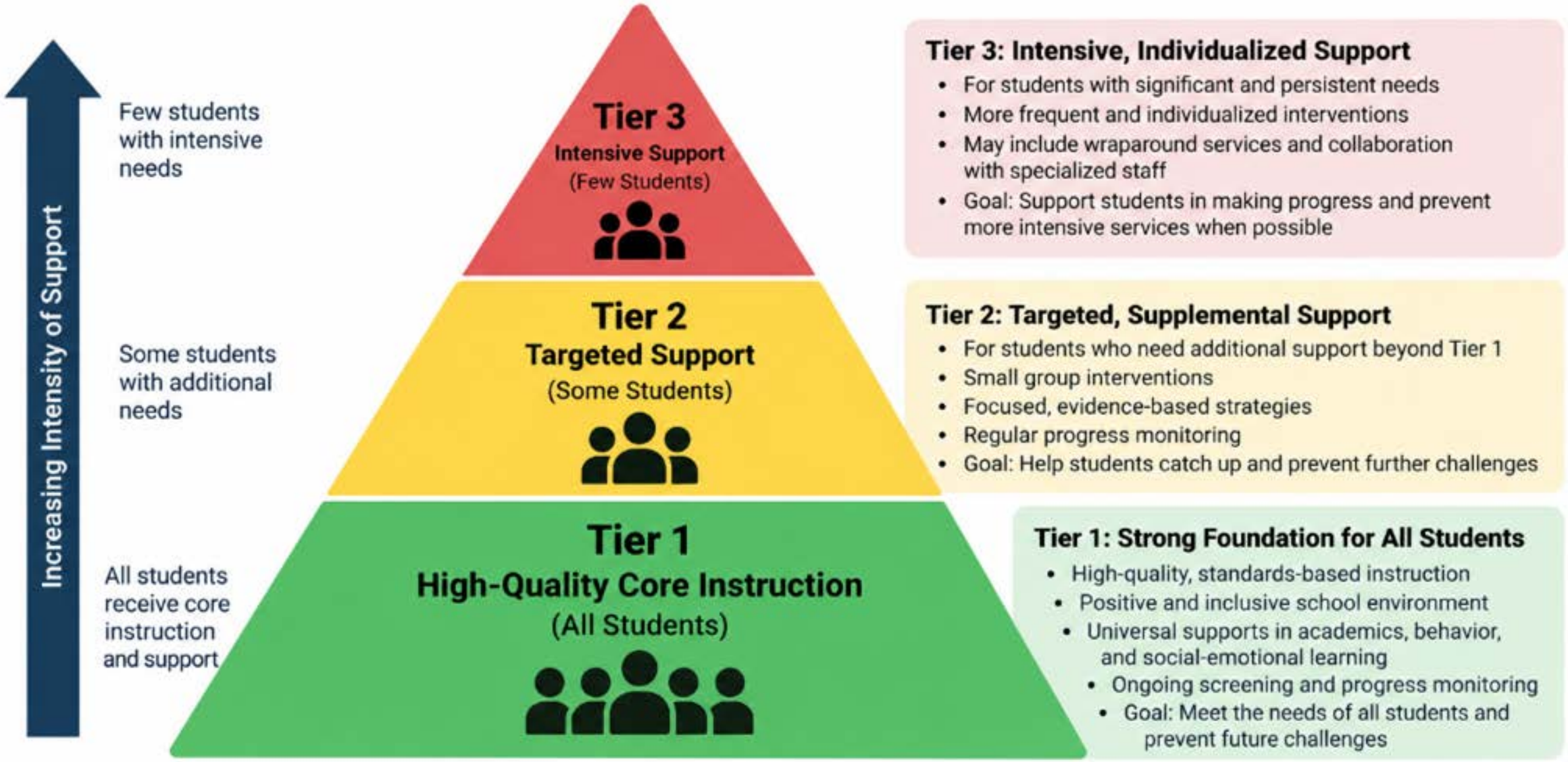
Key Findings

1. Lack of Coherent Instructional Services Structure
2. Ineffective MTSS Implementation Driving Costs
3. Chronic Absenteeism and Weak Attendance System
4. Declining Enrollment and Underutilized Capacity
5. Underdeveloped Enrollment Growth Strategy

Current Instructional Services Organizational Chart



MTSS: Multi-Tiered System of Supports



Tier 3: Intensive, Individualized Support

- For students with significant and persistent needs
- More frequent and individualized interventions
- May include wraparound services and collaboration with specialized staff
- Goal: Support students in making progress and prevent more intensive services when possible

Tier 2: Targeted, Supplemental Support

- For students who need additional support beyond Tier 1
- Small group interventions
- Focused, evidence-based strategies
- Regular progress monitoring
- Goal: Help students catch up and prevent further challenges

Tier 1: Strong Foundation for All Students

- High-quality, standards-based instruction
- Positive and inclusive school environment
- Universal supports in academics, behavior, and social-emotional learning
- Ongoing screening and progress monitoring
- Goal: Meet the needs of all students and prevent future challenges

Ineffective MTSS Implementation Driving Costs



MTSS Reset & Handbook



Individual Student MTSS ⟶ Schoolwide Systems Focus

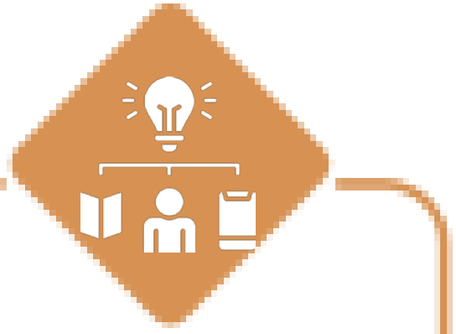


Reintroduced Continuous Improvement Cycles



Defined Schoolwide MTSS Teams & Coordinator Role

Ineffective MTSS Implementation Driving Costs



MUSD Coherence Framework



Classroom Responsibility: Tier 1 & 2



Training Principals & MTSS Coordinators



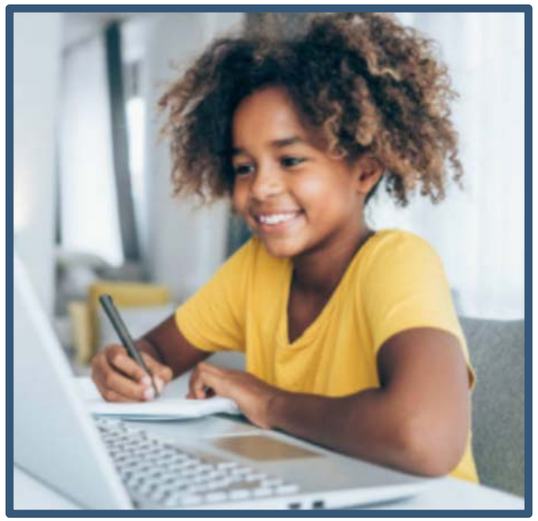
MTSS Coordinator Meeting Structure

Chronic Absenteeism and Attendance

Strengthen Attendance Systems & Supports



Expanded Short-Term Independent Studies



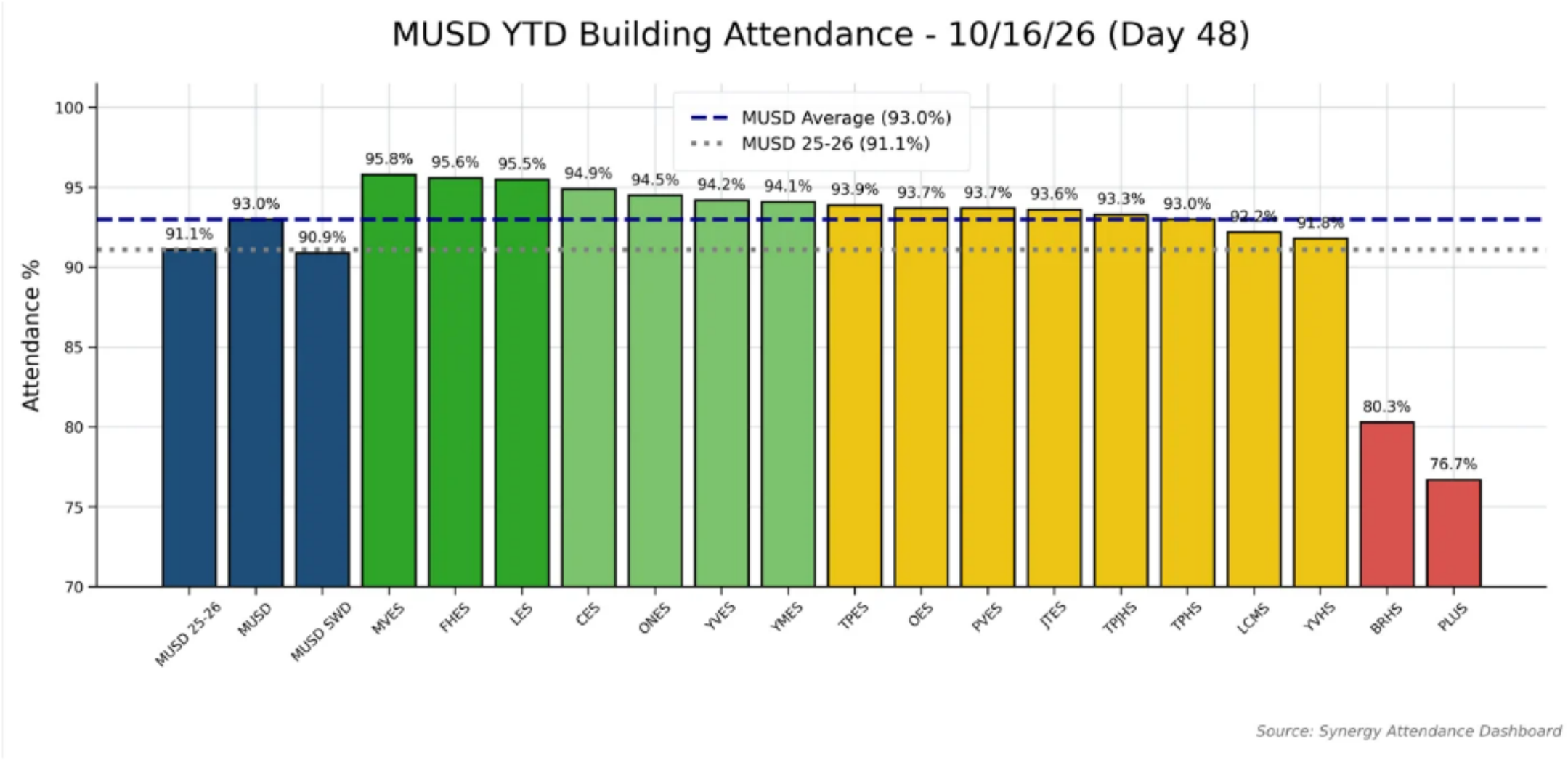
Probation Officer & Home Visit Support



Attendance Campaigns & Incentives

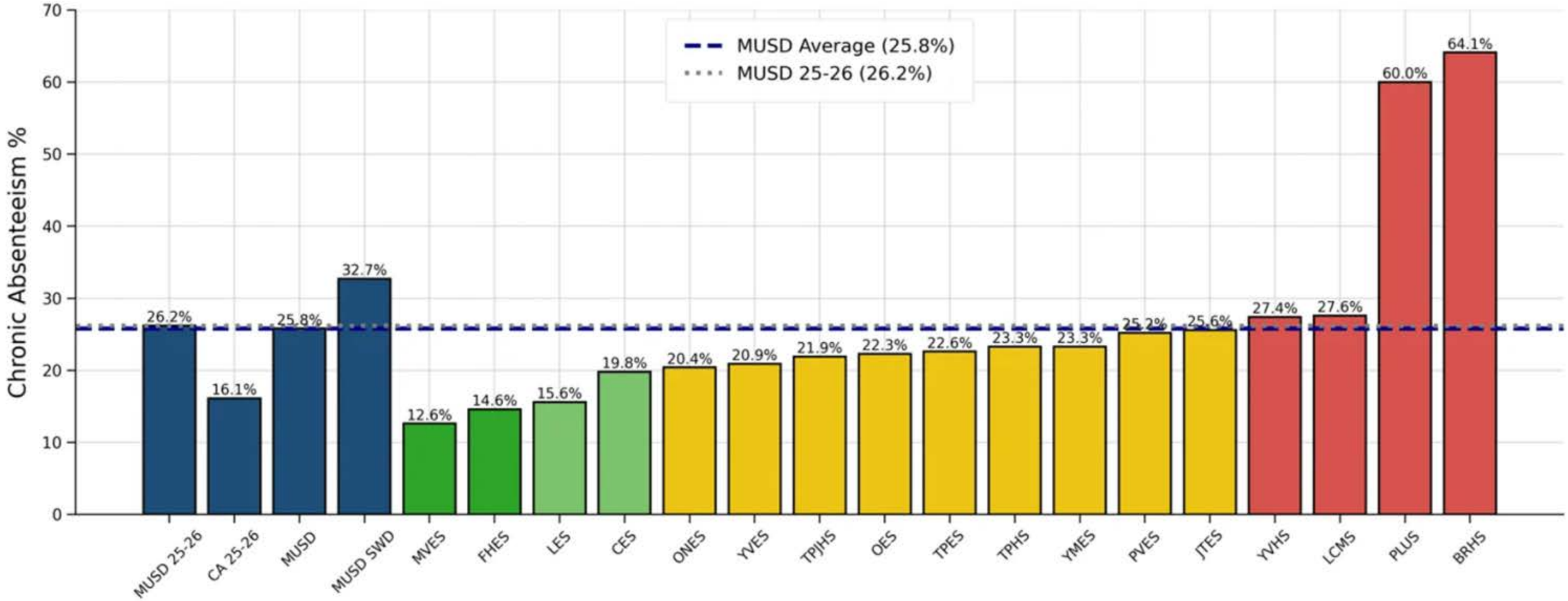


Attendance Year-to-Date

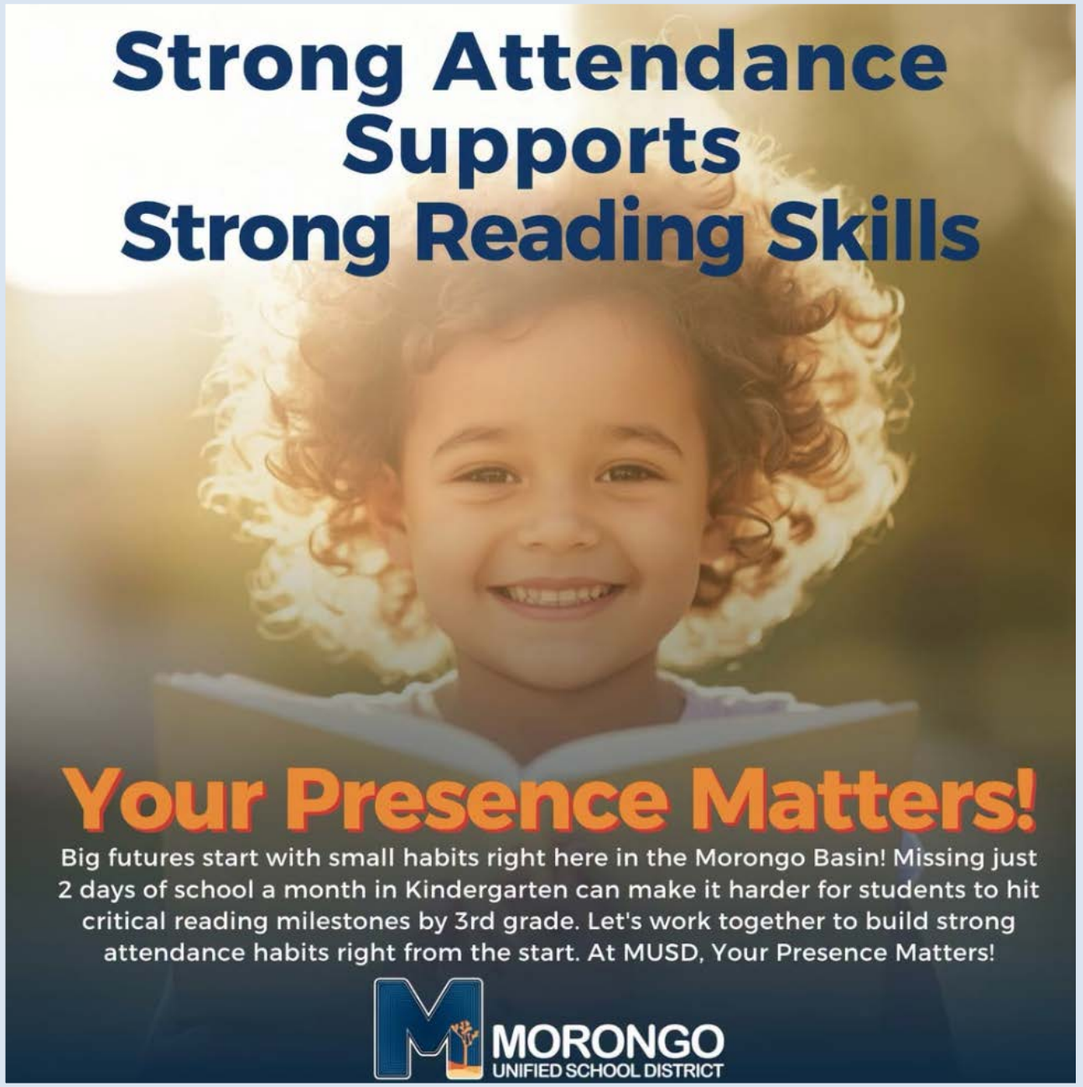


Source: Synergy Attendance Dashboard

Chronic Absenteeism Year-to-Date



Chronic absenteeism rate improved from 2024-25 (28.1%) to 2025-26 (26.2%): reduced by 1.9%


Strong Attendance Supports Strong Reading Skills
Your Presence Matters!
Big futures start with small habits right here in the Morongo Basin! Missing just 2 days of school a month in Kindergarten can make it harder for students to hit critical reading milestones by 3rd grade. Let's work together to build strong attendance habits right from the start. At MUSD, Your Presence Matters!
MORONGO
UNIFIED SCHOOL DISTRICT


MORONGO
UNIFIED SCHOOL DISTRICT
Your community is incomplete without you.
School is so much more than just grades. It's where our kids find their crew, discover their passions, and connect with trusted MUSD teachers and mentors. Our classrooms aren't the same without your child. You belong here at Morongo Unified, and Your Presence Matters!


Attendance is a Healthy Habit.
Just like brushing teeth or eating well, going to school every day is a vital health habit! Regular attendance lowers childhood anxiety, sharpens social skills, and builds routine.
Let's make healthy school habits a priority across Morongo Unified this September!
At MUSD, Your Presence Matters!

Enrollment Growth Strategies

Independent Study Program Expansion

- Expand current ACCE Program Offerings
  - Hybrid model (access to enrichment)
- Expand & develop 100% virtual program at all levels

- **Independent Study**
  - Long-term
  - Daily morning virtual check-ins
  - 1 Weekly, in-person session w/assigned teacher - 1 hour

- **Virtual Academy**
  - 100% Online
  - Daily morning virtual check-ins
  - 1 Weekly, virtual session w/assigned teacher - 1 hour



Special Education

Department Progress

Staffing Supports

Speech-Language Pathology

Recommendation: Conduct a comprehensive SLP caseload audit and bring caseloads into compliance with Education Code.

- An additional SLP has been hired to bring caseloads into compliance.
- Start date: December 2026.
- Funding: Medi-Cal; no additional expense to the General Fund.

School Nurses

Recommendation: Develop a credentialed school nurse staffing increase plan.

- A third school nurse began October 15, 2026. Funded through Medi-Cal, with no additional General Fund expense.
- Phasing out unlicensed health technician positions through attrition and reclassification.

Section 504: Plans, Handbook and Training

Review cases where accommodations alone may be appropriately addressed through a 504

Handbook and Training

- Handbook: Reviewed and uploaded to the Beyond SST database for 504 Coordinator access.
- Training completed: All 504 Coordinators received individual training; School Psychologists were also trained.
- Next steps: Training for MTSS Coordinators and Site Administrators is planned for future meetings.
- Approach: Continue training on an ongoing basis.

Section 504 (ADA): Provides classroom accommodations and support so eligible students with disabilities can learn alongside peers in general education. Eligibility requires an impairment that substantially limits a major life activity.

IEP (IDEA): For students who require special education services and individualized goals.

Special Education Staffing

Completed an MUSD Special Education Staffing Audit

Coordination and Impact

- The audit aligns with the HR Position Control Tool.
- Review special education positions quarterly and reconcile them using Human Resources' new Position Control Tool.

Progress

- Three additional special education teachers were added across district programs.
- Special Education is working with Human Resources to review part-time versus full-time Instructional Assistant positions.

Audit utilized the FCMAT Special Education Efficiency Tool to compare staffing with state industry standards.

FCMAT (Fiscal Crisis & Management Assistance Team) provides fiscal assistance, comparison reports, calculators and tools to help local educational agencies guide financial decisions.

Program Alignment and Service Models

SELPA Workload and Role Realignment

- Moved some itinerant staff evaluations to Site Administration
- Moved the PLUS Program to Alternative Education Programs
- Realigned programs within SELPA leads
- Continue reviewing position-control averages with Human Resources

Service and Revenue Reviews

- Occupational Therapists: Evaluate MUSD employee versus contracted services.
  - Status: In development.
- Medi-Cal: Examine whether additional staffing to support billing could increase district revenue.
  - Status: In development.



Information Technology

Department Progress

Areas of Focus

Communications systems

VoIP procurement in process
PA/bell RFP under development

Device lifecycle

Funded five-year planning aligned to available resources

Take-home model

Recommendation not to commit to full grades 5–12 model

Organization & staffing

Vacancy filled
Restructuring complete
Ratio adjusted

Communication Systems

VoIP Phone System

Savings ≈ $74,000 / year

- RFP completed
- Multiple solutions evaluated
- Procurement is in process
- Enhanced capabilities
- Starlink backup communications included at every site

PA & Bell Systems

- IT, M&O, and engineering consultant working to finalize the RFP
- Non-proprietary standards intended to reduce vendor lock-in, minimize increased support costs, and offer the ability to support/expand with internal employees
- Estimated bid opening: December 2026–January 2027

Devices

Refresh when necessary, refurbish when practical, and redistribute where the device remains instructionally appropriate.

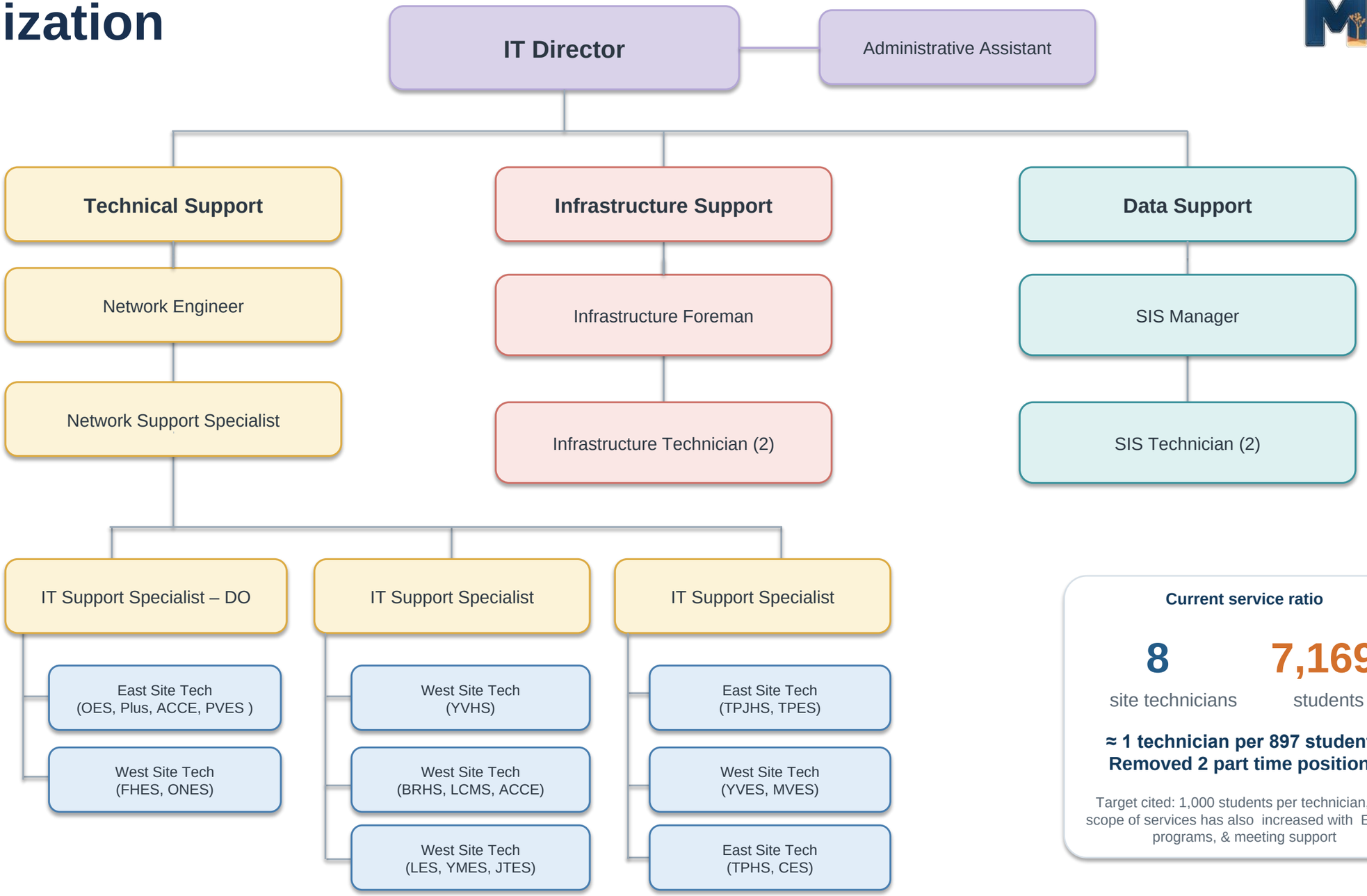
Five-Year Device Refresh Plan

- Annual funding projections reduction by $800K+/year
- Purchasing & device types were modified in response to chip shortages and increased technology costs
- Current strategy prioritizes refurbishment and redistribution to delay avoidable replacement expense

Grade 5-12 Take Home Plan

Maintain K–12 cart-based device use rather than commit to districtwide grades 5–12 take-home devices due to equipment and replacement costs, increased staffing and repair needs, training requirements, potential classroom disruptions, and concerns about non-educational home use.

Organization



Current service ratio

8 site technicians

7,169 students

≈ 1 technician per 897 students
Removed 2 part time positions

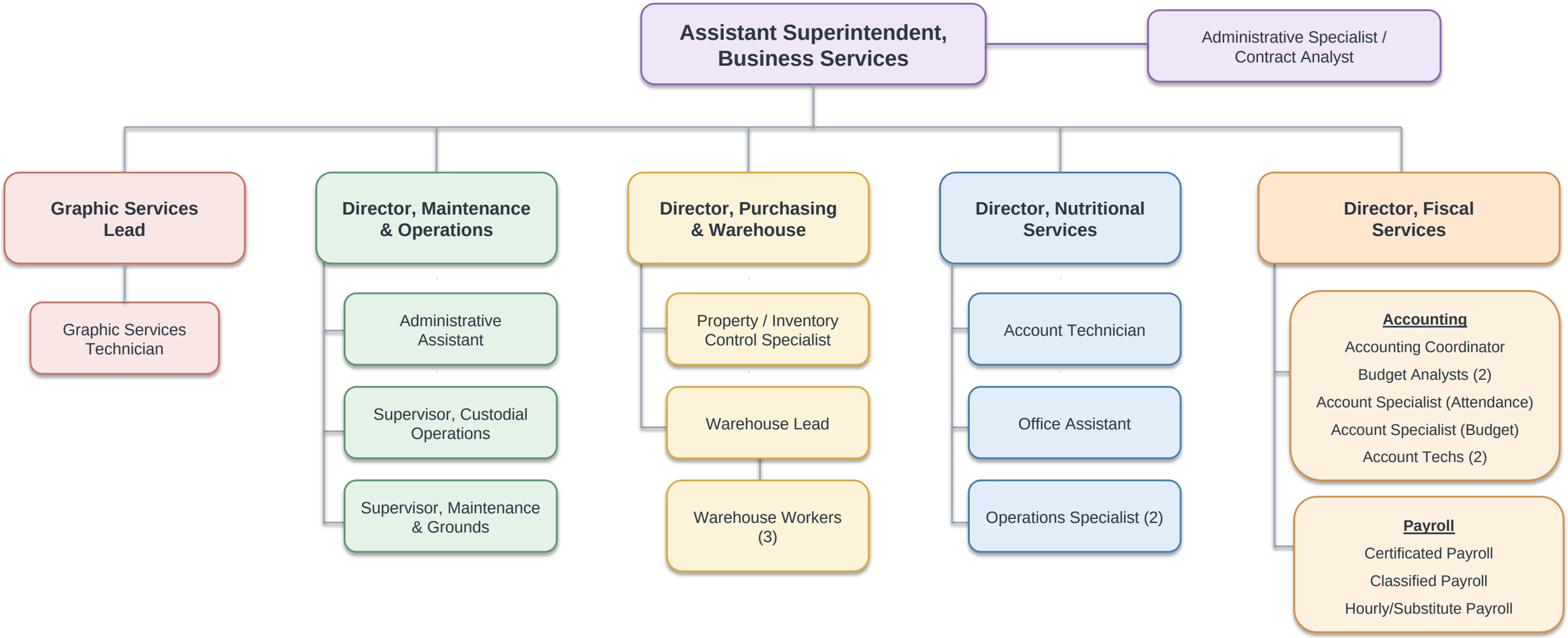
Target cited: 1,000 students per technician, but scope of services has also increased with ELOP, programs, & meeting support



Business Services

Department Progress

Organization



Maintenance and Operations

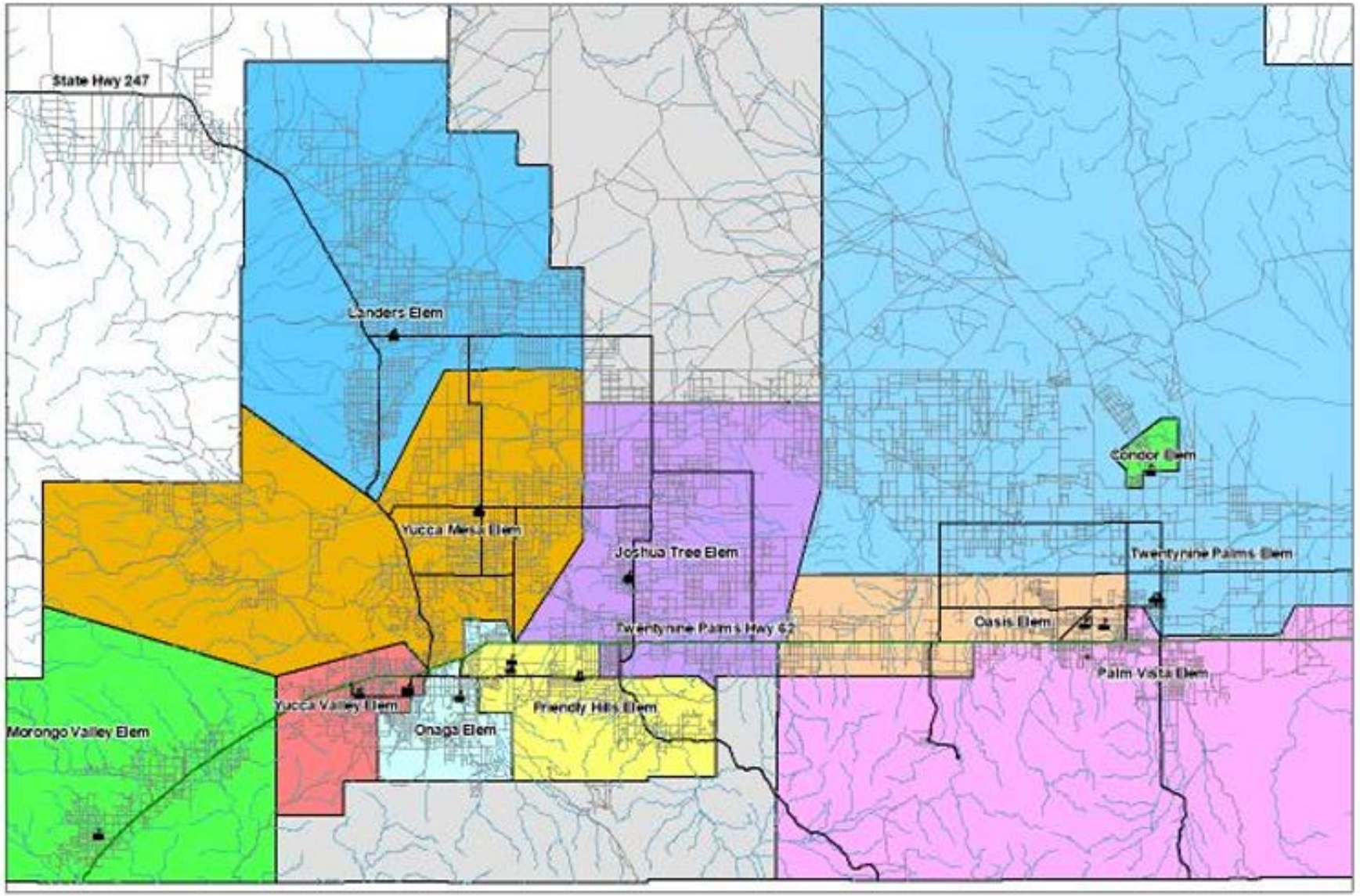
- **Reduction in Maintenance Staff (13 to 9):** Could be achieved through attrition and reclassification of existing positions. However, a reduction of this magnitude is expected to have operational impacts. **Not recommended.**
- **Reduction in M&O Management/Lead Positions:** Could be achieved through attrition but would require organizational restructuring. The operational impacts are currently unknown.
- **Custodial:** No staffing reductions recommended at this time.
- **Grounds:** Currently understaffed by approximately four positions. While no overall staffing increase is recommended, converting at least one proposed maintenance position reduction into a grounds position is recommended to better address operational needs.

**Note: Maintenance is funded from a contribution to 8150 from the general fund at minimum state required 3% of GF expenditures. This means any reductions in positions funded out of 8150 are not a savings to the general fund and do not necessarily address deficit spending.*

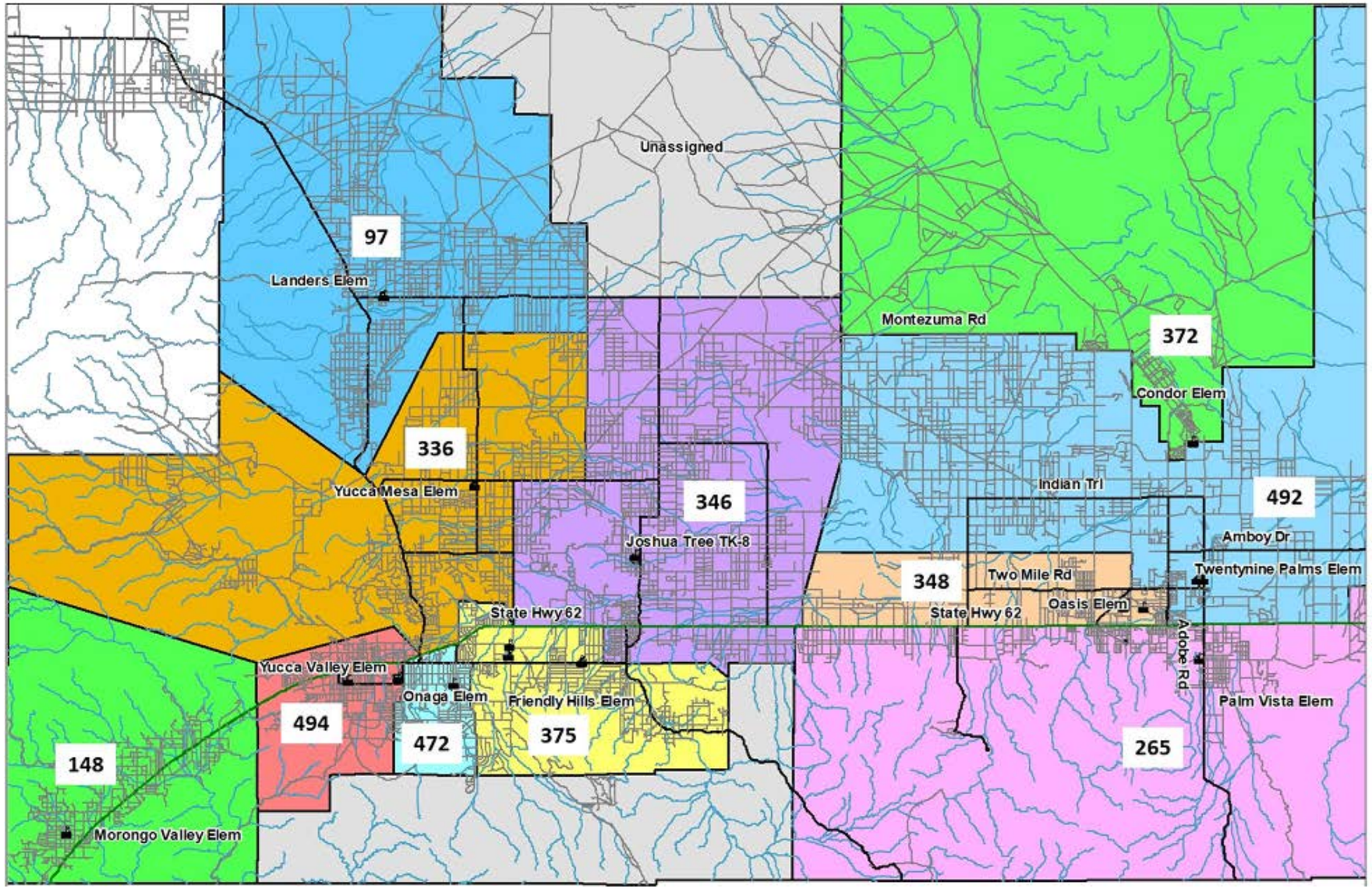
Facilities

- **Sale of Surplus (*Unused/Vacant*) Property:** Requires funding for appraisals, with proceeds generally reinvested in improvements to other facilities. Properties must be declared surplus by the 7–11 Committee and receive Board of Education (BOE) approval before sale. **Not recommended at this time.**
- **Repurposing:** Address underutilization by closing or repurposing underutilized classrooms and buildings to better align facilities with current needs.
- **Consolidation:** None
- **Facility Use/Leasing:** Not a reliable source of additional revenue. Fees are intended to offset facility-use costs and reflect the limited revenue potential of the rural market. Most facility use is reciprocal with other local agencies or supports internal groups.
- **Re-boundarying:** Potential scenarios are presented on the following slides.

Current Boundaries



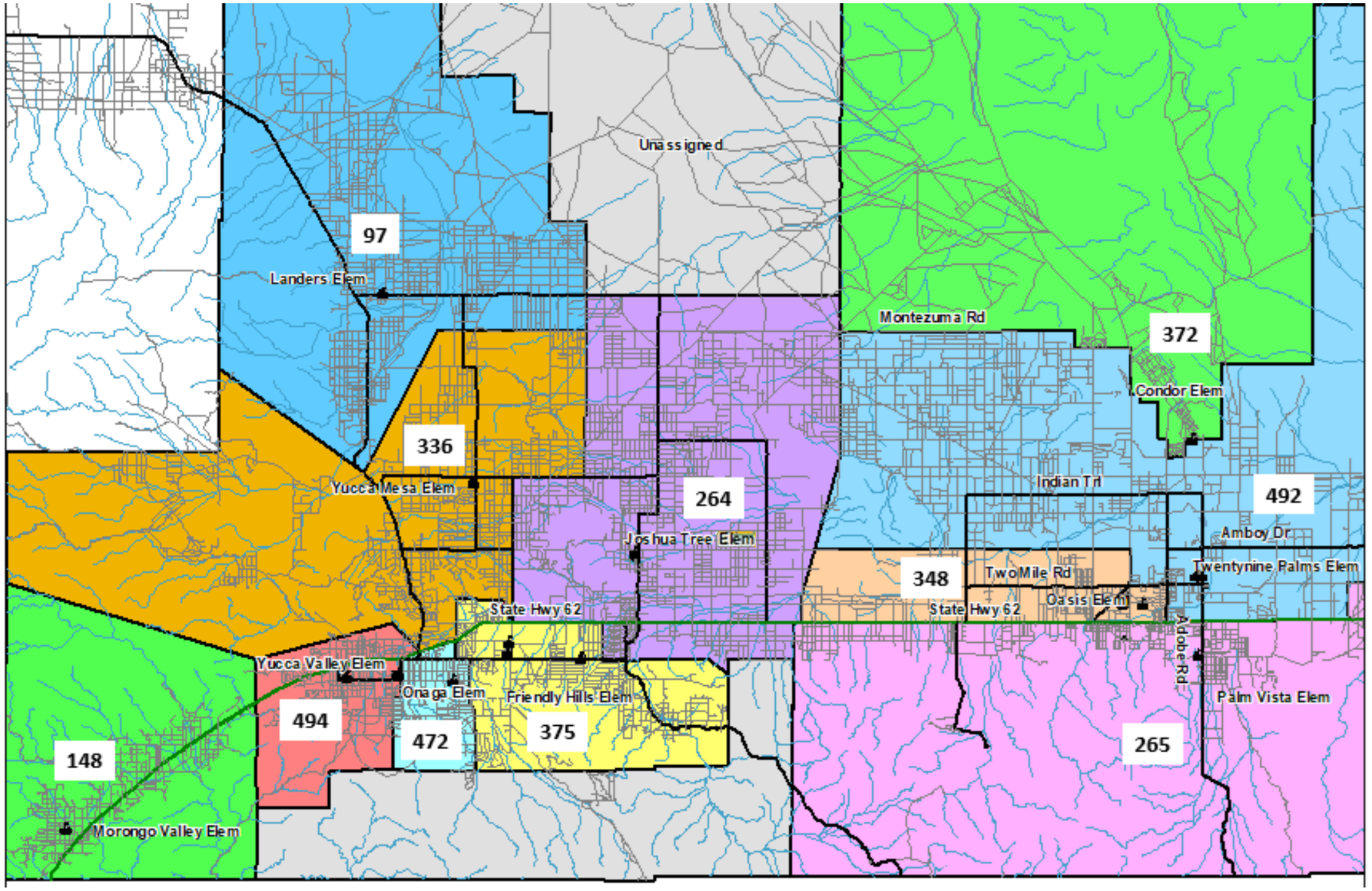
Scenario 1 Boundary Map



- Joshua Tree expands to grades TK-8
- Schools boundaries adjusted for improved balancing

**Projections assume current transfer patterns*
All scenarios use 2027-28 Projections

Scenario 2 Boundary Map



- Schools boundaries adjusted for improved balancing

**Projections assume current transfer patterns All scenarios use 2027-28 Projections*



Thank You

Questions?